Stringere (v0.0.1)[1]

Lauge Dideriksen, 1 November 2026

Stringere is perhaps one of the most ambiguous concepts in Italian rapier fencing. Part of this, might be due to the lack of good English (or German) translations. In English one often finds 'gain', or 'find', or 'stringer'. Some teachers also use 'constrain' which, while not a direct translation, gets at the nature of the action. I use either 'gain' or the italian 'stringere', although the latter results in somewhat awkward passive constructions. This document does not try to make sense of how the concept is presented in different sources.[2] Instead, I have tried to describe how I think about, and teach, stringere. The first section describes my notion of stringere—what it is, what it does, and how it does it. The second section contains the drills I use to teach it. If I teach the topic on its own, I usually spread it across two classes, but I use many of the same drills when working on other concepts, reviewing the principles of stringere in the process.

1. Principles of Stringere

On my view, a stringere does two things and facilitates a third. It limits the opponents options, keeps the fencer protected while doing so, and makes it possible to increase pressure on the opponent.

2. Drills

These are the drills I use when teaching the topic of stringere. If I teach the topic on its own, I usually divide it into two classes. The first class covers drills Ia.–IIb.; the second class reviews drills Ic. and IIa., and covers IIIa–e.

I do each drill for three rounds on each side (inside/outside): first round very slowly, second round at a pace that feels smooth, third round pushing the pace just beyond what is comfortable. Contrary to other topics, where I will let pairs of students work on a drill for a longer period of time, I have each pair do a drill one time each before rotating to a new partner.

I. Basics.
   a. A gives a line; B performs a stringere with a gathering step; if A sees an opening for a direct attack, A strikes.
   b. As Ia., but B's gathering step must bring them into middle range. If A sees no opening for a direct attack, B strikes with a thrust in opposition.
   c. As Ib., but if A sees an opening for a direct attack at any point, they strike.

II. Common reactions to a stringere.

[1] This document is part of a collection of texts on Italian rapier fencing, and may reference parts that are not included here. The current version of the full collection can be found on https://github.com/laugedideriksen/ItalianRapier.

[2] David Biggs has written an excellent blogpost (2025) trying to do just that.

a. A gives a line; B performs a stringere with a gathering step; A performs a disengage (cavazione) and a thrust in opposition.
b. As Ib., when B attacks, A counters *stesso tempo*, with or without a void, with or without an empty-hand parry.

III. Counters to IIa.
a. As IIa.; B counters *a dui tempi*.
b. As IIa.; B counters *stesso tempo* with a void.
c. As IIa.; B counters *stesso tempo* with without voiding, with or without an empty-hand parry.
d. As IIa.; B attacks into A's disengage with a thrust in terza (stoccatta).
e. As IIa.; B counters with a counter-disengage (countracavazione) and a thrust in opposition.

References

Biggs, David. 2025. 'So, Just What Is a 'Stringere'?'. Substack newsletter. October 2. https://davidbiggs.substack.com/p/so-just-what-is-a-stringere.